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Reflections and Lessons from the Internship

During this summer, I was able to have the opportunity to work as the marketing and social media intern for Garrett Brands. Garrett Brands is a Chicago-based company that many know through their success with Garrett Popcorn. Although most of the brand is based in Chicago, they do have stores throughout the US and Asia, and they are currently working on breaking into the grocery/retail market. This was my second summer working for them. I had a lot of the same roles as my previous year, but I also gained more responsibilities and experiences that were different from my previous year. I worked 40 hours a week and worked from June to the beginning of September. This role was a hybrid role, which I enjoyed. Daily, I would manage Garrett's social media accounts, manage community engagement through Sprout Social, and assist with various projects and campaigns. I would help create paid ads for their social media platforms, work on influencer relations and partnerships, and assist in brainstorming sessions for our holiday campaigns. Aside from those tasks, I also attended many field marketing events throughout the city of Chicago. Most of these events were to promote our new RTE (Grocery) line of Garrett Popcorn.

One new thing that I learned this summer was the importance of influencer marketing. It was extremely valuable to see the whole process for reaching out to influencers, negotiation, brief drafting, execution, and invoicing. I found this incredible to see how much our brand grew and gained more followers and customers through the use of influencers. I think it is so important in our world today. Additionally, one thing I also learned in terms of our RTE line was

the importance of field marketing events to increase brand awareness. By having activations at different events throughout Chicago, our fans learned more about our product and learned that we were in grocery stores now. I also learned the steps that go into building a campaign from the beginning stages of just brainstorming to the execution. It was fascinating to see the number of steps and minds that go into every step of a marketing campaign. One thing I also learned was the importance of social media for our products today. If a new recipe or something else went “viral” on TikTok or Instagram, it would dramatically increase our sales. I think this demonstrates how important social media marketing is today due to its popularity across many generations.

One thing that really surprised me was how fast our RTE Popcorn grew. It was so interesting to see the growth between the two summers since I had the opportunity to work there for two years. My first summer, we were just beginning to get into mostly local grocery stores. This summer, we had grown way beyond. We are now in all Walmarts, Sam's Club and Costco, and retailers throughout the Midwest. It is so interesting to see the growth and how much can be done in a year. I found it fascinating to see the deals being made and the RTE line growing. I think one thing that made them so successful was slowly growing outside of Chicago, where people are more familiar with the brand. I found it to be exciting and surprising, the growth that happened within a year. Another thing that surprised me was the strategy behind Garrett Popcorn's expansion into the retail space. Instead of going all at once on a national level, they started small to slowly gain more local recognition and strength, and then became stronger on a slower level. I found this to be one of the bigger factors in their success.

This internship will be something that I will continue to use and discuss during job interviews. One thing that can be incredibly helpful in job interviews is the experience I learned

through working in influencer and social media marketing. This is a newer sector of marketing that I believe my experience gives me an upper hand in. I can discuss how I managed several of our influencer outreach programs and how it had a large impact on Garrett Popcorn's growth as a company. I can also discuss how I learned and developed skills in social media strategy when creating organic and paid content. I think it is valuable to discuss how I was able to have hands-on experience with developing campaigns from the bottom up and being able to manage projects, such as how I did with our Gen-Z summer campaign. A final thing I can discuss in job interviews is how I saw the company first-hand grow into the retail sector through various strategies, such as field marketing events, increasing our social media presence, and more. I think it is incredibly important to discuss these aspects and how I had a part in the company's success in their growth into retail through setting up influencer marketing programs and continuing to increase our social media presence.

I found that I had a lot of observations during my time at Garrett that related to the EMPAC model. In terms of entertainment, I found this to be incredibly important. Garrett prides itself on being a fun brand that engages many. This comes from being featured at sports games and many more big celebration events. I think one thing that was incredibly important in terms of entertainment was our use of social media and influencer marketing. This allowed us to engage the customer with the brand in a different way. Through the use of creating content that was trendy and relatable, it was able to increase our brand's engagement with younger viewers.

For Matching, I think it was incredibly important that we found influencers and other brands to collaborate with that align with our brand's values and image. One way we did this was by teaming up with many Chicago-based influencers to highlight our brand identity of being a Chicago-born and bred brand. Additionally, we were able to partner with many iconic Chicago

events, such as the Bud Billiken parade in the South Side and the Chicago NASCAR Street Race. Through attending events, we were able to demonstrate the fun nature of our brand and our support for the city of Chicago while also getting our product out to new fans. One thing that was also a part of our matching was collaborating with brands that aligned with Garrett for giveaways and partnerships. This can be seen with our newest collaboration with Home Run Inn Pizza to create Chicago Pizza Popcorn. I was a part of the team that facilitated this collaboration, and it was extremely impactful to our brand image because these are two iconic Chicago brands coming together to create such a unique product. I think it was also important to match our retail assortment to different grocery stores based on our clientele. For our stores outside of Chicago, we also included more original recipes rather than just the Garrett Mix.

In terms of price, our LTO recipes (limited-time offer) and our promotions allowed us to create more of an incentive for the customers to purchase. During the summer, we had a “hot summer deals” campaign that had promotions throughout the summer to increase sales. We also constantly feature new limited-time recipes that are available online to have customers want to try something new, different, and exciting. This allowed us to try new recipes to see if we wanted to add them to our normal lineup and keep Garrett's gourmet image.

This also plays into our Assortment. We are constantly rotating different collaborations and seasonal recipes. In terms of our RTE- during the summer, we featured more summery flavors that play into summer activities such as Smoked BBQ. Additionally, our collaboration with Home Run Inn to create Chicago Pizza Popcorn was a great way to keep our offers new and exciting while at the same time continuing to have our classic recipes.

I think convenience was a big factor that I observed growth in during my time at Garrett. Through Garrett's expansion into grocery stores such as Walmart, Costco, and Sam's Club.

Garrett Popcorn became extremely more accessible to people in any state. Now, fans do not have to go find a legacy store (which are mainly in Chicago) or order online to get Garrett Popcorn. Throughout the United States, Garrett Popcorn can now be spotted at several different airports, grocery stores, and even some airlines such as United. Garrett's accessibility has grown an increasing amount in the past few years, allowing it to become extremely convenient, and people can integrate Garrett Popcorn into their everyday routine at the grocery store or while in an airport.

My internship at Garrett Popcorn equipped me with several important skills in marketing and social media marketing, and gave me hands-on experience with growing into the retail market. Additionally, I was able to gain first-hand experience in influencer marketing, social strategy, field marketing and developing campaigns. I gained invaluable experience through working and collaborating with several amazing people and being able to witness their creativity and expertise. This allowed me to understand that this is something that I want to do in the future and allowed me to learn several lessons and skills I will use in future careers.